When Mulayam Singh was chief minister in 2006, cars would routinely be stolen from outside the office premises. We complained but got no response. When Mayawati took charge a year later, we complained again. A police booth was set up just outside the office. The car thefts stopped.

Just as worrying was the fragile social peace. In the first year of Akhilesh's government, there were more than a hundred large and small communal riots. Akhilesh insisted that the riots were the brainchild of the BJP–VHP combine. *'Phayda to unhi ko hota hai dangon se'* (The BJP–VHP are the ones who benefit from riots), he claimed. The pattern of the riots was suspicious—any small incident could trigger a bandh call from saffron groups and spark off tension and violence. Local Sangh Parivar leaders, it seems, were spoiling for a fight.

And yet, the fact is the SP was also playing the politics of religious polarization. During the Ram Janmabhoomi movement in 1990, Mulayam had ordered police firing on kar sevaks on their way to Ayodhya, to prevent them from reaching the disputed site. It was a controversial decision, but one that earned him the loyalty of the UP Muslims. It was the Muslim–Yadav base that had since sustained his politics.

But what started off as an attempt to maintain law and order eventually became a rather blatant policy of Muslim appeasement. From job reservations to promises to withdraw cases against Muslim youth accused of terror, the SP government became almost totally identified with the politics of the minorities. Matters reached a stage where the joke in UP's power circles was that if any politician with a topi and *dadhi* met Mulayam, he would be given ministerial rank and a lal-batti car. 'It had gone out of control, there was bound to be a backlash,' says senior Lucknow-based journalist Sharat Pradhan.

The Muzaffarnagar riots only exposed the fault lines further. In December 2013, I visited Muzaffarnagar along with an NGO to help in the relief and rehabilitation efforts. Many of the riot displaced were still living in tents in the bitter winter cold, too frightened to go back to their homes. Religious organizations and local madrasas had more or less taken over the relief camp, providing blankets and firewood. I had brought cricket kits for